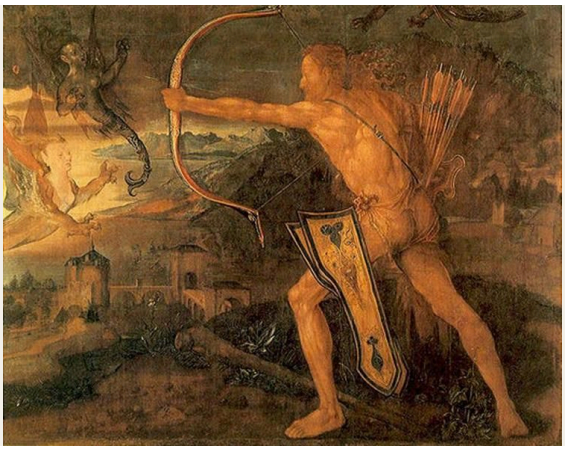
NUREMBERG, GERMANY

Germanisches Nationalmuseum: Masterpieces

Twenty works about effort, occupation and the roles made visible through a pose.



Hercules draws a bow with his back turned. An older sister carries a child. Between those actions lies a substantial difference in subject and status, but both paintings must make weight and effort intelligible through the body. That practical question is a useful way into this selection from the Germanisches Nationalmuseum.

Other figures are less physically active. A book, a habit, heraldic signs or theatrical costume may establish what kind of person a portrait presents. Those attributes should not be mistaken for complete access to a sitter's character. Across these works, compare what a body does, what its surroundings say about it, and what the image leaves unknown.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/germanisches-nationalmuseum

The selection · 20

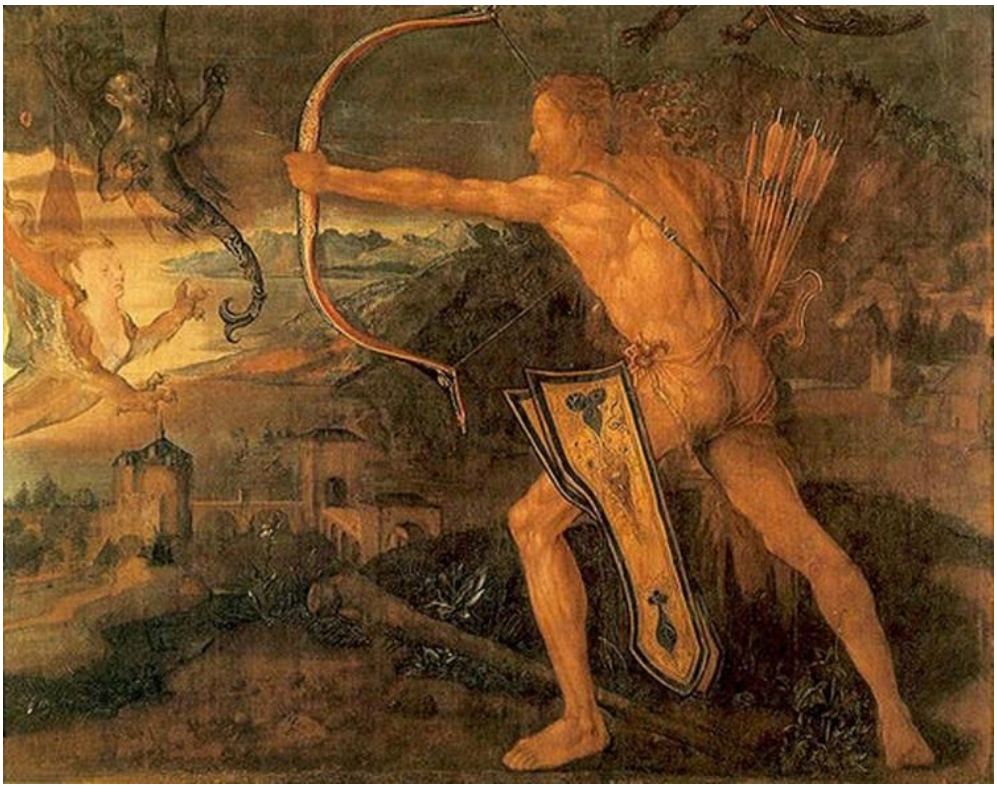
1. Hercules Fighting the Stymphalian Birds
   Albrecht Dürer · 1500
2. Johannes Reuss
   Lucas Cranach the Elder · 1503
3. Annunciation
   Konrad Witz · 1440
4. Battle of the Amazons
   Anselm Feuerbach · 1870–1873
5. Behind the Scenes
   Eduard von Grützner · 1870
6. Michael Wolgemut
   Albrecht Dürer · 1516
7. Nuremberg's Main Market from the South
   Lorenz Strauch · 1594
8. Martin Luther as an Augustinian Monk
   Lucas Cranach the Elder · 1523
9. Fool with a Needle and Ass's Ears
   Andreas Herneisen · c. 1590
10. Cornelia Adriana Munter and Her Daughter
    Johann Friedrich August Tischbein · 1798
11. Emperor Maximilian I
    Albrecht Dürer · 1519
12. Tegernsee Landscape
    August Macke · 1910
13. The Rosé Quartet
    Max Oppenheimer · 1924
14. Two Girls
    Max Pechstein · 1909
15. Head in Black and Green
    Alexej von Jawlensky · 1913
16. Ideal Landscape with the Temple of Juno at Agrigento
    Jacob Philipp Hackert · 1794
17. Judith with the Head of Holofernes
    Hans Baldung · 1525
18. Madonna and Child with Parrots
    Hans Baldung · 1533
19. Nativity of Christ
    Wilhelm Stetter · 1525
20. The Elder Sister
    Fritz von Uhde · 1883

01 / 20

Hercules Fighting the Stymphalian Birds

Albrecht Dürer

1500 · Tüchlein painting on plain-weave linen · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Hercules kills the Symphalic Bird. WikiArt; Albrecht Dürer. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The drawn bow turns Hercules into a study of opposing forces. His back faces the viewer, yet the rotation of the body makes the direction of the shot legible. Dürer uses the mythological task to test how movement can be understood from an awkward view. The fantastic creatures supply the target; the hero's anatomy supplies the immediate problem.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 5379

02 / 20

Johannes Reuss

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1503 · Oil on panel · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Lucas Cranach the Elder. Johannes Reuss. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/lucas-cranach-the-elder/johannes-reuss-1503 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

An open book brings the sitter's hands into the portrait's account of identity. Red cap and robe connect head and torso, while trees frame the face against a landscape. Cranach does not rely on expression alone to introduce Reuss. Reading, clothing and setting work together as the public terms through which an individual is presented.

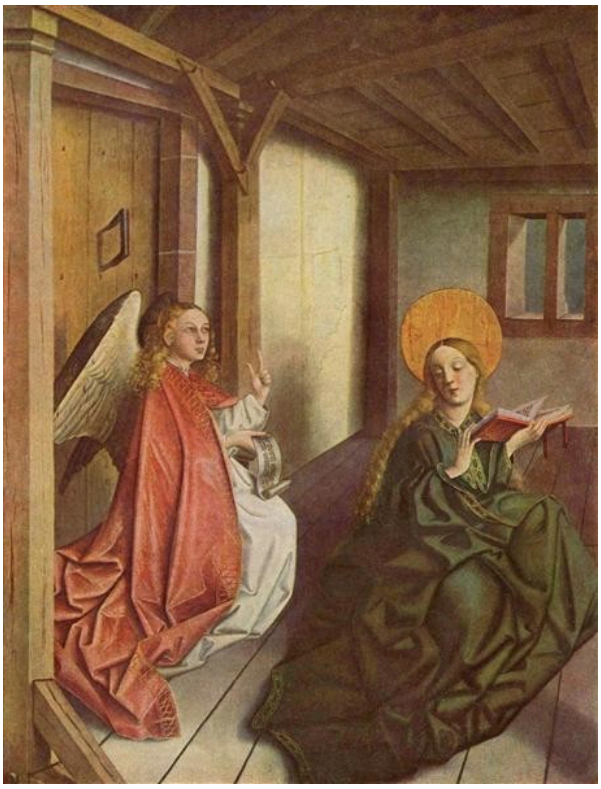
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Annunciation

Konrad Witz

1440 · Germanische Nationalmuseum



Konrad Witz. Annunciation. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The timbered room puts physical limits around the encounter. Low ceiling, walls and heavy folds of cloth give the angel and Mary a shared material setting. Konrad Witz makes the sacred event happen within a space that has to accommodate bodies. Its closeness matters: the room resists becoming an indefinite backdrop behind two symbolic figures.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Battle of the Amazons

Anselm Feuerbach

1870–1873 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Anselm Feuerbach. Battle of the Amazons. Image credit: Anselm Feuerbach. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

A rearing horse carries one part of the struggle above the surrounding bodies. Across the wide field, repeated limbs and opposing movements connect separate encounters. Feuerbach makes conflict readable through an extensive arrangement rather than one decisive blow. The broad format gives the eye time to move between groups, even while their actions resist a stable balance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm2054

05 / 20

Behind the Scenes

Eduard von Grützner

1870 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Eduard von Grützner. Behind the Scenes. Image credit: Eduard von Grützner. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Away from the stage, costumes continue to announce roles that the wearers are not currently performing. Grützner divides the company into smaller groups of standing and seated figures. Waiting becomes a subject alongside theatrical display. The distinction between a performer and a character grows easier to notice when the apparatus of performance remains visible during a pause.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Michael Wolgemut

Albrecht Dürer

1516 · Limewood (Tilia species) · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



© Bayerische Staatsgemäldesammlungen (als Dauerleihgabe im Germanischen Nationalmuseum Nürnberg). Albrecht Dürer, Bildnis Michael Wolgemut, 1516. https://www.sammlung.pinakothek.de/de/artwork/M0xyZ1VLpl CC BY-SA 4.0; compressed study reproduction. · CC BY-SA 4.0

The dark cap and plain ground leave the face with little competition. Dürer follows the uneven contours around eyes, cheeks and mouth rather than smoothing age into a generalised emblem of wisdom. The portrait's specificity lies in those differences. It presents an old man as a particular person without requiring an invented psychological explanation for each line.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 700

07 / 20

Nuremberg's Main Market from the South

Lorenz Strauch

1594 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Lorenz Strauch. View of the main market in Nuremberg from the south. Image credit: Lorenz Strauch; Source credit: Photo from a reproduction. Wikimedia Commons. CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC BY-SA 4.0

The enclosing buildings define a civic space, while stalls and small figures divide it into places of activity. Strauch's church façade anchors the view without absorbing the market around it. Architecture becomes legible through use as well as outline. The small scale of the people allows many separate occupations to remain visible within one account of the city.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Martin Luther as an Augustinian Monk

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1523 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Lucas Cranach the Elder. Portrait of Martin Luther as an Augustinian Monk. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Habit and book establish a religious role before a fuller history of the sitter is supplied. One hand rises near the chest while the other remains associated with the book. Cranach keeps the face particular within those recognisable signs. The portrait records a mode of presentation, not a face in which every later event can already be read.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Fool with a Needle and Ass's Ears

Andreas Herneisen

c. 1590 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Andreas Herneisen. Depiction of a Fool with Needle and Ass's Ears. Image credit: Sailko; Required attribution: I, Sailko. Wikimedia Commons. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC BY-SA 3.0

The needle brings the hands close to the grinning face, enlarging a small action within the tight frame. Exaggerated ears in the headgear identify the comic role before the gesture is fully understood. Herneisen makes costume and action reinforce one another. The figure is presented as a performance of foolishness, not as an ordinary portrait accidentally caught in an awkward pose.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm1548

10 / 20

Cornelia Adriana Munter and Her Daughter

Johann Friedrich August Tischbein

1798 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Johann Friedrich August Tischbein. Double portrait of Cornelia Adriana Munter (1770-1828) and her daughter Eleonore Louise Hedwig von Bose (1797-1831). Image credit: Daderot. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The child is held within the larger body's space. Pale faces and clothing emerge from the dim setting above the mother's green dress, making their contact easy to follow. Tischbein gives the double portrait its structure through unequal scale and physical proximity. No additional incident is needed to show the practical relation between holding and being held.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm1337

11 / 20

Emperor Maximilian I

Albrecht Dürer

1519 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Albrecht Dürer. Emperor Maximilian I. Image credit: Albrecht Dürer. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The face is only one part of the imperial presentation. Inscription, heraldic signs and rich clothing extend the sitter's identity beyond likeness into public authority. Dürer's arrangement makes that machinery visible. It is useful to separate what the features tell us from what the accompanying signs declare, rather than treating rank as something naturally apparent in a person's appearance.

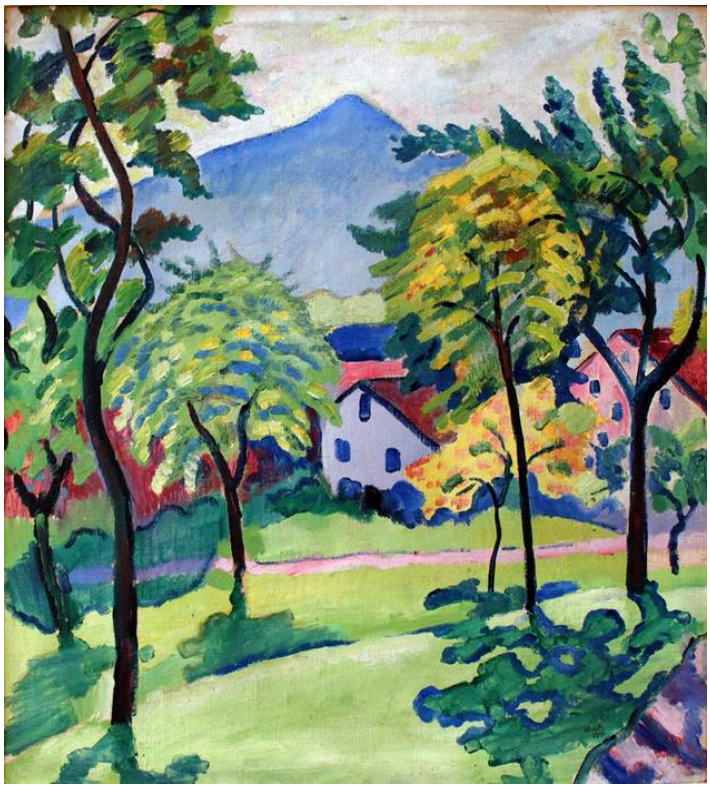
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm169

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Tegernsee Landscape

August Macke

1910 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



August Macke. Tegernsee Landscape. Image credit: August Macke. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Bright colour patches make trees, buildings and mountains fit together around the open slope. Macke keeps the terrain recognisable without subordinating every colour to naturalistic shade. Blue and yellow accents can establish relations across different objects. The landscape is organised by how these patches meet as much as by the distances that they describe.

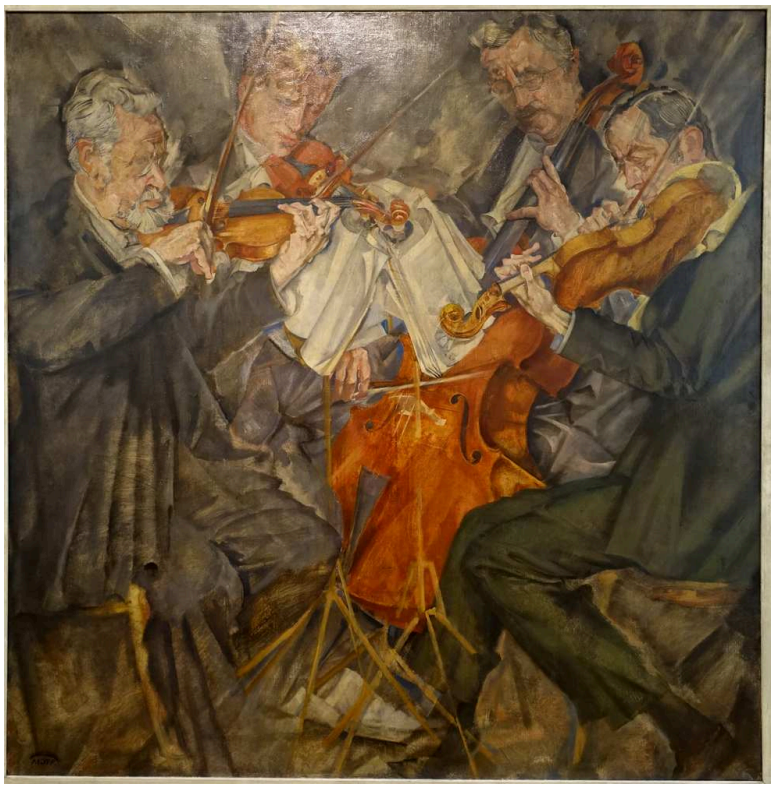
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm2034

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The Rosé Quartet

Max Oppenheimer

1924 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Max Oppenheimer. Rose Quartet. Image credit: Max Oppenheimer. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Arms, bows and instruments overlap so closely that individual actions become part of a larger web. Oppenheimer gives ensemble playing a visible structure without reducing the four musicians to identical movements. Each has a separate task inside the shared performance. Repeated lines connect them, while the bodies and instruments retain the differences required to make a quartet.

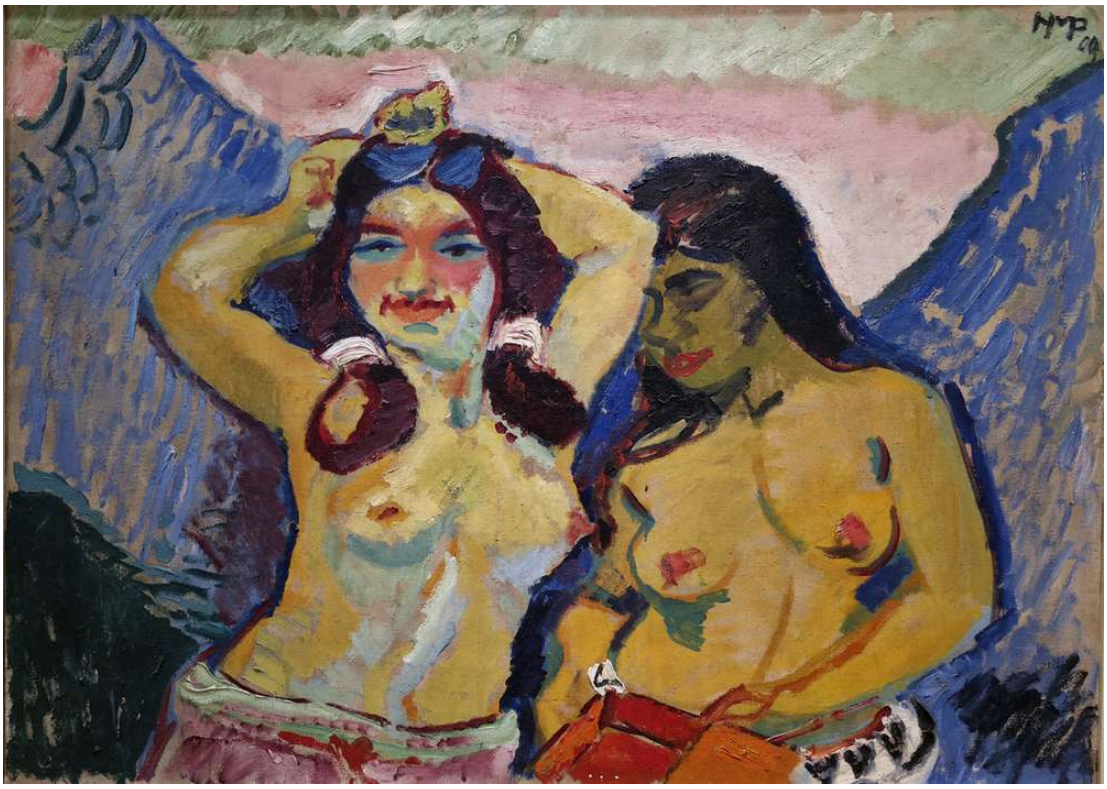
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm2035

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Two Girls

Max Pechstein

1909 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Max Pechstein. Two Girls. Image credit: Max Pechstein; Source credit: Ölgemälde. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

One figure's raised arms interrupt the possibility of a symmetrical pair. Pechstein relies on broad outlines and strong colour to hold the bodies against their surroundings. The contrast in posture remains more consequential than fine anatomical description. Sitting close does not make the figures equivalent; their differing gestures give the arrangement its internal movement.

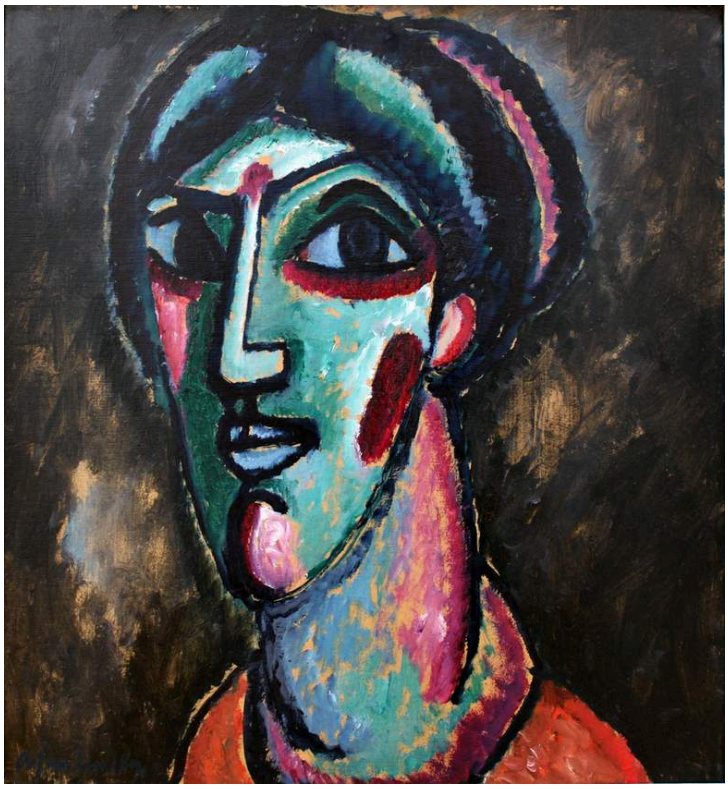
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm1680

15 / 20

Head in Black and Green

Alexej von Jawlensky

1913 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Alexej von Jawlensky. Head in Black and Green. Image credit: Alexej von Jawlensky. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Green, blue, pink and black cease to describe ordinary skin, but the enlarged eyes and long nose preserve a face. Jawlensky tests how much recognition depends on arrangement rather than local colour. The head remains readable through the position and proportion of a few features, even as its surface refuses the conventions of a naturalistic likeness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm1671

16 / 20

Ideal Landscape with the Temple of Juno at Agrigento

Jacob Philipp Hackert

1794 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Jacob Philipp Hackert. Ideal Landscape with Juno Temple of Agrigento. Image credit: Jacob Philipp Hackert. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Ruins, water, trees and small figures have been brought into an ordered prospect. The word “ideal” in the title is useful: the painting need not be treated as an unedited view from a single spot. Hackert connects architecture and terrain through arranged passages into the distance. The result invites movement through a composed landscape rather than a topographical checklist.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm2040

17 / 20

Judith with the Head of Holofernes

Hans Baldung

1525 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Hans Baldung Grien. Judith with the Head of Holophernes. Image credit: Hans Baldung Grien. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Judith's upright, sharply outlined body appears composed beside the sword and severed head. Baldung places the violent result within a presentation that does not resemble the action of killing. The contrast complicates a simple heroic pose. Narrative knowledge and the still figure must be held together; neither alone accounts for the uneasy relation between body and attributes.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm1093

18 / 20

Madonna and Child with Parrots

Hans Baldung

1533 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Hans Baldung Grien. Madonna with Child and Parrots. Image credit: Hans Baldung Grien. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The twisting child prevents the devotional pair from becoming a fixed, balanced emblem. Parrots add further points of activity near the figures, while dark drapery makes the pale bodies distinct. Baldung introduces movement into a familiar close grouping. The birds can first be noticed as compositional interruptions without assigning them an unsupported symbolic meaning.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm1170

19 / 20

Nativity of Christ

Wilhelm Stetter

1525 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Wilhelm Stetter. Nativity of Christ. Image credit: Wilhelm Stetter; Source credit: Objektkatalog der Sammlungen des Germanischen Nationalmuseums. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The Nativity occupies a setting with more than one centre of activity. Stetter's buildings divide the picture into connected spaces, permitting distant figures and surrounding worshippers to coexist with the newborn child. The eye can leave the central group and return through architectural passages. The sacred event belongs to a larger inhabited world rather than filling the image alone.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm1210

20 / 20

The Elder Sister

Fritz von Uhde

1883 · Germanisches Nationalmuseum



Fritz von Uhde. The Elder Sister. Image credit: Fritz von Uhde. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Care has a weight here. The older girl carries the smaller child on her back, and Uhde makes that practical task the basis of their relation. Side light distinguishes faces and worn clothing within the modest room. The scene does not need an extraordinary event to be consequential; responsibility is already visible in the load one child bears.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Gm1788

From heroic effort to ordinary work

Return from the elder sister to Hercules and compare how each body carries force. The subjects differ greatly, but both depend on a legible pose. Some collection works are loans, and holdings do not guarantee display; check the museum's current information for individual objects.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s chapters on contour, tone and the arrangement of figures give practical language for comparing Dürer’s close description with Jawlensky’s strongly coloured head and Oppenheimer’s musicians.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12